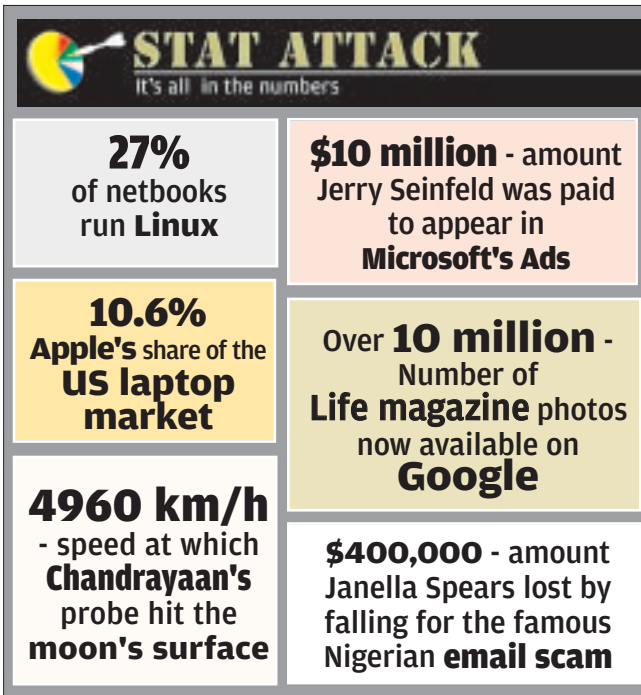




understandable. For many of us, IM has become second nature, but we can't really see ourselves saying "OMG!" to our parents, who would likely not be as comfortable with IM as we are. We're willing to wager that most of, if not all, the participants were young, and have grown up IM-ing. As we've used the medium, so have we adapted to it, and made it almost as good as personal interaction.

ENTER DAVID

ARMs In Your Hand?

Even as Intel pummels its competition in every processor category, there is another

voice that comes a-challenging.

ARM — the processor that has been powering our smartphones and PDAs and PMPs and miscellaneous pocket-sized devices — will now poke its head into the booming netbook market, which has thus far been dominated by Intel's Atom. The company will work with Canonical to build a flavour of Ubuntu optimised for the new ARMv7 architecture, and is targeting netbooks of all shapes and sizes.

There is much to be said in favour of this move. Firstly, as you might have doubtless noticed, your (ARM-based) smartphones can last for a goodish while before needing a charge. If ARM does it right, they are better poised to give us a

netbook with spectacular battery life than anyone else. For, you see, while Intel's trying to get its x86 chips to consume less power, the ARM architecture was designed with power consumption in mind right from the beginning. Secondly, there's video. ARM's mastered the art of playing high-quality video without consuming too much power, and a souped-up ARM might even be able to handle HD video with more finesse than the Atom. Finally, there's the fact that ARM's RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computing) architecture is inherently more efficient than the x86 architecture, so in the right hands, the ARM could potentially outperform the Atom.

The same RISC that makes the ARM so great, could also be its undoing. A badly written block of code could throw off its performance considerably, thrashing all our dreams of a fast netbook that lasts a whole day on a single charge. And you know you don't want that.

BEEP BEEP

Jaguar Overtakes Roadrunner

Just as so many gamers must compare 3DMark scores to validate their gamer-hood, research labs must spend their time

building supercomputers that can do more stuff per second than anything else. In June, IBM's Roadrunner became the first supercomputer to cross the petaflop barrier, performing 1.026 quadrillion floating-point operations per second (flops), making it the fastest supercomputer in the world.

Back in 2004, Cray started adding more processors to their extensible Jaguar XT supercomputer, taking it from 84 cabinets to 284. They've built one that they can add on to whenever they feel like. Today, the Jaguar runs on 45,000 quad-core Opterons, making that a total of 180,000 cores, and hits a peak performance of 1.64 petaflops, clearly unseating the Roadrunner.

The Jaguar will give scientists all the computing power they need to figure out the weather, nuclear fusion, and generally anything that perplexes them. And here we are, just talking when there's science to do.

THE JIG IS UP

LCD Prices All Show

There's nothing like a good economic crisis to get people to do desperate things. AIG, for example, begged for a government bailout so their

Buzzword of the MONTH

Bhuvan

Now that the ISRO has somewhat conquered the moon, they're ready to take on even more space-related projects. The first off the block will likely be Bhuvan, our own answer to Google Earth. Like Google Earth, Bhuvan will use a network of satellites to watch the world, and let us zoom into areas around 10 metres wide, as compared to Google Earth's 200. And just like Google

Earth has cities in the US so wonderfully mapped, Bhuvan is likely to give us that same goodness right at home.

But why build a competitor to Google Earth in the first place? Apart from the fact that the pictures for India aren't as detailed as those for the US, Google Earth also updates only every two or three years. Bhuvan, on the other hand, will update once a year.